OMNIHACK · USER MANUAL

# How to use OmniHack

A complete guide to the ideathon and hackathon platform, for participants, judges, mentors, organizers, recruiters and platform administrators. Find your role in the contents and follow the steps.

Covers the web app at version 1.0  Updated 20 October 2026

## 01 What OmniHack is

OmniHack runs innovation competitions from the first registration to the final certificate.

Organizations such as colleges, companies, communities and nonprofits host three kinds of competition:

- **Ideathon:** participants submit and pitch ideas. Nothing needs to be built.
- **Hackathon:** participants build a working project during a sprint and demonstrate it.
- **Ideathon → Hackathon (hybrid):** ideas are judged first, and the best ones go on to build prototypes.

Every competition moves through **stages**, such as registration, idea submission, judging rounds and the final presentation. Judges score each judged stage against a published rubric. Winners are announced on a results page, certificates are issued with a public verification code, and hiring partners can offer internships and jobs to participants who opt in.

## Who does what

| ROLE | WHAT YOU CAN DO | READ |
|---|---|---|
| **Participant** | Register, form a team, submit work, see feedback and results, download certificates, join the talent pool | §04–§07 |
| **Judge** | Score assigned projects with a rubric, declare conflicts of interest | §08 |
| **Mentor** | Support assigned teams and review their submissions | §09 |
| **Organizer** | Create and run competitions, review registrations, assign judges, publish results, issue certificates | §10–§14 |
| **Recruiter** | Post openings, browse consenting candidates, shortlist, interview and make offers | §15 |
| **Sponsor rep, auditor, volunteer, ops** | Limited views for their duty | §16 |
| **Platform admin** | Approve competitions, verify organizations, manage users, read enquiries | §17 |

Roles are given **per competition**. The same account can be a participant in one competition and a judge in another. Your sidebar shows only the areas you have access to.

# 02 Your account

One account works for every role. Anyone can browse competitions without an account, but you need one to take part.

## Create an account

1. Select **Sign up** in the top-right corner of any page.
2. Enter your full name, your email address and a strong password. Your name is printed on certificates, so use the name you want to appear there.
3. Accept the terms of use and privacy notice, then select **Create account**. You land on your dashboard.
4. Open the verification email and select **Verify email**. The link confirms that the address is yours.

## Verify your email address

Until you verify, a yellow banner on the dashboard says *Verify your email address*. Some actions are blocked until you do, such as creating an organization. To verify:

- Find the email titled **Verify your email · OmniHack** and select its link. Check your spam folder if it doesn't arrive within a few minutes.
- If the link has expired or the email is missing, use **Resend** on the dashboard banner.
- Check the address you signed up with on **Profile & security**. A typo such as `gmai.com` means the email can never arrive.

**RUNNING OMNIHACK ON YOUR OWN COMPUTER?**

When no email service is configured, OmniHack does not send real emails. It prints each email, including the verification link, to the terminal window running the server. Look for a line starting with `[email:console]`, then copy the `http://localhost:3000/auth/verify-email?token=…` link into the browser where you are signed in. To send real emails, the site operator sets `EMAIL_PROVIDER=smtp` and the `SMTP_*` settings.

## Sign in and out

- Select **Sign in** and enter your email and password. Several failed attempts in a row are rate-limited, so wait a little before trying again.

- If you turned on two-factor authentication, you are then asked for the 6-digit code from your authenticator app.
- Forgot your password? Select **Forgot password** on the sign-in page. You receive a reset link by email, and it works once.
- To sign out, use the account menu in the top bar.

## Profile & security

Open **Profile & security** in the sidebar.

| AREA | WHAT IT DOES |
| --- | --- |
| **Profile** | Full name, headline, bio, skills, institution, country, GitHub and LinkedIn. Teammates and organizers see this, and recruiters see it if you join a talent pool. Skills help teams find you. |
| **Privacy** | Choose whether your name appears on public showcase and winner pages when your team opts in, and whether you receive emails about new competitions. Both are off unless you turn them on. |
| **Two-factor authentication** | Scan the QR code with an authenticator app, then confirm a code. You need a code to turn it off again. Platform admins may be required to use it. |
| **Password** | Change your password. You must enter your current one. |
| **Active sessions** | See where you are signed in and sign out other devices. |
| **Your data** | **Download my data** gives you a JSON copy of your personal data. **Deactivate** closes your account after you confirm with your password. |

## Notifications

The bell in the sidebar shows unread updates: registration decisions, team invitations, announcements, deadline reminders, judging assignments, results and hiring news. Important updates are also sent by email. Select a notification to go straight to the page it refers to, and mark items read individually or all at once.

# 03 Finding competitions

Open **Competitions** in the header, or **Find competitions** in the sidebar.

- **Search** by title, topic or organizer.
- **Filter** by type, status (registration open, upcoming, in progress, completed), format (online, in person or hybrid), eligibility (students, professionals, startups, open to all), participation (individual or team), fee, deadline, category, organizer, and **Careers → Internships & jobs offered**.
- Filters are saved in the page address, so you can bookmark or share a filtered list.
- Cards show the phase, deadline, format and team size. A green Hiring badge means hiring partners have open roles.

## The competition page

Each competition has a public page with these sections:

- **Overview:** the tagline, description, organizer and the current registration state, such as *Registration open*, *Registration opens soon*, *Registration full* or *Registration closed*.
- **Challenges and tracks:** the problems you can choose from.
- **Timeline:** every stage with its dates, shown in the competition's time zone.
- **Eligibility and team rules:** who can join, and the minimum and maximum team size.
- **Prizes:** overall, track, special, sponsor and non-monetary awards.
- **How you are judged:** each judged stage's criteria and weights.
- **Judges, mentors and sponsors:** shown only when they have agreed to appear publicly.
- **Internships & jobs:** open roles from hiring partners, when the competition has any.
- **Rules, FAQ and contact.**

After results are published, a **Results** page lists winners and finalists. It never shows scores.

# 04 Registering and your workspace

## Register for a competition

1. On the competition page, select **Register**. You need to be signed in.
2. Choose your participant type: student, professional or startup. OmniHack checks this against the eligibility rules and tells you straight away if you don't qualify.
3. Answer any questions the organizer added, such as your institution, age (only if the competition has an age rule) or T-shirt size.
4. Accept the competition rules and submit.

Your registration then has one of these statuses:

Under review | Approved | Waitlisted | Not approved | Withdrawn

- Some competitions approve everyone automatically. Others review each registration by hand, and you are notified of the decision.
- If the competition is full, you may be **waitlisted**. You are moved up automatically when a place opens.
- You can **withdraw** from your workspace while the competition allows it.

## Your competition workspace

Open the competition from **Overview** on your dashboard. Your workspace shows:

- Your status and the next deadline.
- Your **team**, or the options to create or join one.
- The **stage timeline**, showing which stage is open and what is due.
- **Submissions** for every stage that accepts them.
- **Feedback** released by the organizer, and whether you advanced.
- **Announcements** from the organizers.
- **Presentation slots**, if you have been scheduled for a pitch or demo.
- Your **check-in QR code** for in-person events.
- **Showcase**: a request to publish your project in the public gallery after the event.
- **Career opportunities**, if the competition has hiring partners. See §07.
- **Need help?**: a support request sent to the organizers.

# 05 Teams

Only for competitions that allow teams. Individual competitions skip this section.

## Create a team

1. In your workspace, select **Create team** and give it a name. You become the team leader.
2. Invite members by email, or share the team's invitation link. Invitees open `/invite/…`, sign in and accept.
3. Each member must be registered and approved for the competition. A person can be in only one team per competition.

## Find a team or find members

- Leaders can describe the team and tick **Looking for members**.
- Approved participants open **Find a team** from the workspace. It lists open teams, their seats left and their skills.
- Select **Request to join** and add a short message. The leader is notified and can invite you.

## Team rules

- The team size must be within the competition's minimum and maximum before you can submit.
- Leaders can remove members and hand over leadership. Members can leave.
- Rosters lock when the organizer says so, usually when judging starts.

# 06 Submissions, feedback, results and certificates

## Submit your work

1. When a submission stage opens, its form appears in your workspace. Depending on the stage, it asks for things like a problem statement, solution, pitch deck, demo video link, repository link or file uploads.
2. **Save a draft** as often as you like. Team members share the same submission.
3. Select **Submit** before the deadline. You can update a submission until the stage closes, and every update creates a new version.

- Deadlines are shown in the competition's time zone, with a countdown.
- If the organizer allows late submissions, they are accepted but marked **late**.
- Uploaded files are checked by type and size, and may be scanned for malware. A file that fails the scan is blocked.

## Judging, feedback and advancement

After a judged stage closes, judges score each project. When the organizer releases feedback, you see it in your workspace together with your decision: Advanced or Not advanced. Only advanced projects can submit to later stages. How scores are calculated is explained in §18.

## Results

Results are approved by the competition owner before they are published. The public results page then lists winners and finalists by prize. It never shows scores.

## Certificates

- Organizers issue participation, finalist and winner certificates, and mentor, judge, volunteer and organizer certificates. You are notified when yours is ready.
- Download yours as a PDF from **Certificates** in the sidebar.
- Every certificate has a code. Anyone can check it is genuine at `/verify`, so add it to your CV or LinkedIn.
- A revoked certificate shows as revoked when someone verifies it.

## Project showcase

After the event, your team can request publication in the public **Projects** gallery. The organizer approves each request. Member names appear only if the team chose to show them and each member's privacy setting allows it. You can withdraw a published project at any time.

# 07 Internships & jobs

Companies hire through competitions. They see the work you built, not only your CV. Nothing is shared unless you opt in.

## Browse open roles

Open **Careers** → **Internships & jobs** in the header, or go to `/opportunities`. Filter by internship, pre-placement offer, full-time or contract, and by on-site, remote or hybrid. Each role links to its competition, and you apply by taking part in that competition.

## Join the talent pool

1. Register for a competition that has hiring partners and wait for your registration to be approved.
2. In the workspace, find the **Career opportunities** card.
3. Choose what you are interested in, plus your preferred locations, availability date and graduation year. You can also upload a PDF CV of up to 5 MB.
4. Decide whether hiring partners may read your submitted project.
5. Tick **I confirm I am 18 or older** and the consent box, then select **Join the talent pool**.

WHAT RECRUITERS SEE

- **They can see:** your profile, preferences and CV; your certificates; your project, if you allowed it; and your awards. Once results are published they may also see a rough band such as "Top 25%".
- **Only after a company shortlists you:** your email address, shared with that company.
- **Never:** judges' scores or comments.

## Track interviews and offers

Open **Internships & jobs** in the sidebar. A badge appears when something needs your answer.

Shortlisted → Interview invited → Interview scheduled → Offer received → Offer accepted

- **Interview invited:** read the time and format, then select **Accept interview**. You can add a message, for example your availability.
- **Offer received:** read the details, then select **Accept offer** or **Decline**. The formal offer letter comes directly from the company.
- **Withdraw** leaves a process at any stage before the end.

To leave the talent pool, select **Leave the talent pool** on the workspace card. Your profile is hidden at once, your CV is deleted and open applications are closed.

# 08 Judges

An organizer adds you as a judge, and you receive an email and a notification. **Judging** then appears in your sidebar.

1. Open **Judging** to see the projects assigned to you, grouped by stage, with your progress.
2. Open a project to see its submission and the scorecard side by side.
3. **Conflict of interest?** If you know the team or have another interest in the project, select **Declare conflict** before scoring. The project is reassigned, and you are never assigned it again in that competition.
4. Score each criterion within its range. Half points are allowed, and some criteria require a comment. Read the scoring instructions shown with each criterion.
5. Select **Save draft** to come back later. A draft can be incomplete.
6. Select **Finalize** when you are done. Finalizing needs every score and required comment, and it locks your evaluation.

- Judges do not see participants' email addresses, and they do not see other judges' scores.
- Only an organizer with correction permission can change a finalized score. They must give a reason, and the change is logged.

# 09 Mentors

Organizers add you as a mentor and assign you to projects. Open **Mentoring** in the sidebar to see your assigned teams and their members, and to read their submissions so you can advise them. You can only see the projects you are assigned to. With your agreement, organizers may show your name and expertise on the public competition page, and they can issue you a mentor certificate.

# 10 Organizations and creating a competition

## Create an organization

1. Verify your email address first (see §02).
2. Open **Host a competition**. It is called **Organizer console** once you belong to an organization.
3. In **Create an organization**, enter the name and type (company, university, college, school, nonprofit, community, government or other), plus an optional description and website.
4. You become the organization's **Owner**. Add colleagues by their account email as **Owner**, **Coordinator** or **Member**. They must sign up first.

VERIFIED ORGANIZATIONS

A platform admin can mark an organization as verified. Competitions from verified organizations publish immediately. Others are sent to an admin for approval first, with the status *Awaiting approval*.

## The creation wizard

Select **New competition**, choose the type, and work through the ten steps. You can save and leave at any step. The draft stays private until you publish.

| STEP | WHAT YOU SET |
| --- | --- |
| **1 · Basics** | Title, web address (slug), tagline, description, category, language, contact email, banner |
| **2 · Type** | Ideathon, hackathon or hybrid. This decides the default stages. |
| **3 · Delivery** | Online, in person or hybrid; time zone; venue or online instructions |
| **4 · Eligibility** | Who may join, age rules, individual or team participation, team size, capacity, approval mode, custom registration questions (up to 20) |
| **5 · Challenges** | Problem statements and tracks, each public, visible to registered participants only, or hidden |
| **6 · Dates** | When registration opens and closes, and when the event starts and ends. Enter them in the competition's time zone. |
| **7 · Prizes** | Overall ranking, track award, special recognition, sponsor award, non-monetary recognition |
| **8 · Evaluation** | Rubrics for judged stages: criteria, weights (which must total 100%), score ranges, required comments, tie-break order |
| **9 · Rules** | Rules, code of conduct, intellectual-property terms, FAQ |
| **10 · Publish** | Visibility (public, unlisted or private), the publish checklist, and the **Publish** button |

The publish checklist lists anything missing, such as dates in the wrong order or a rubric that doesn't total 100%. Paid registration cannot be published yet, because payments are not enabled.

## Competition lifecycle

Draft → Awaiting approval → Published → Completed → Archived

A published competition can also be **cancelled**, and registrants are notified. The overview tab shows the status history.

# 11 The organizer console

Open a competition from the console to see its tabs. You see only the tabs your role allows.

| TAB | USE IT TO |
|---|---|
| **Overview** | Check key numbers and the publish checklist, change the lifecycle status, and preview the public page |
| **Setup** | Reopen any step of the creation wizard |
| **Stages** | Configure the stage engine (§12) |
| **Registrations** | Filter by status, search, approve, waitlist or reject with a reason, and export CSV |
| **Teams & projects** | See rosters and submissions, and disqualify a project with a reason |
| **People** | Add judges, mentors, ops coordinators, sponsor reps, auditors, volunteers and recruiters; assign mentors to projects |
| **Judging** | Assign judges, follow completion, view rankings, apply advancement, correct scores (§13) |
| **Results** | Assign prize winners, then prepare, approve and publish results |
| **Certificates** | Set the template, bulk-issue by category, revoke and reissue |
| **Event ops** | Run the check-in desk, sessions and schedule, presentation slots, announcements, support requests and volunteers |
| **Analytics** | See registration, team, submission and attendance metrics, with CSV exports |
| **Showcase** | Approve or reject requests to publish projects |
| **Sponsors** | Add sponsors, confirm them (only confirmed sponsors appear publicly), link sponsor awards, see the sponsor report |
| **Hiring** | Manage the talent pool, pipeline, openings and hiring settings (§14) |
| **Audit log** | See every sensitive action, with who did it and when |

### Adding people

On **People**, enter the person's account email and choose a role. Judges and mentors can be shown publicly with their expertise. Recruiters also need a **Company**, and they act only for that company. The person is notified by email.

### Event-day operations

- **Check-in:** scan a participant's QR code with the device camera, where the browser supports it, or check them in by hand with a reason.
- **Slots:** schedule pitch or demo times. Teams see their slot in their workspace.
- **Announcements:** post to all participants. They appear in workspaces and as notifications.
- **Support:** answer the help requests that participants send from their workspace.

# 12 Stages

Each competition type starts with a ready-made set of stages that you can edit, reorder, turn on or off, or extend.

| TYPE | DEFAULT STAGES |
|---|---|
| **Ideathon** | Registration → Eligibility screening (off by default) → Idea submission & preliminary evaluation → Pitch round → Final presentation → Results → Certificates & showcase |
| **Hackathon** | Registration & team formation → Development sprint → Progress checkpoint → Final submission & technical judging → Live demonstrations & final presentations → Results → Certificates & showcase |
| **Hybrid** | Registration → Idea submission & evaluation → Prototype development → Prototype submission & technical review → Final demonstration → Results → Certificates & showcase |

For each stage you set:

- its dates;
- whether it accepts submissions, and which form template and fields it uses;
- whether it is judged, and its rubric;
- whether only advanced projects may take part;
- the advancement rule.

Stage status moves from *Not started* to *Open*, *Closed*, *Judging* and *Completed*. A rubric locks once its stage enters judging.

# 13 Running judging and publishing results

1. **Add judges** on the People tab.
2. **Assign judges** on the Judging tab. Automatic assignment gives each project the minimum number of judges, using the least-loaded judges first and skipping declared conflicts. You can also assign or revoke by hand.
3. **Start judging** on the stage. This locks the rubric.
4. **Follow completion.** A project is complete when it has enough finalized evaluations and no pending ones.
5. **Apply advancement**: top N, top percent, minimum score, or manual. Automatic rules need every project to be complete. You can then override individual decisions.
6. **Release feedback** so participants see their decisions and comments.
7. **Results:** assign winners to prizes and *prepare* provisional results. The competition **owner** then *approves* them. Coordinators cannot approve, which keeps preparation and approval separate. Then *publish*. Publishing notifies participants and opens the public results page.
8. **Certificates:** bulk-issue by category from the Certificates tab.

TIP

Before you publish results, check that sponsor awards and track awards have winners, so sponsors and participants see a complete page.

# 14 Hiring programme (organizers)

1. On **Hiring → Settings**, tick **Enable hiring** and write a note for participants. You can also choose whether recruiters see a rough rank band after results are published.
2. On **People**, add each company's representative with the **Recruiter** role and their **Company**.
3. Post openings on **Hiring → Openings**, or let recruiters post their own. Active openings appear on the competition page and on `/opportunities`.
4. Watch the placement statistics: opt-in rate, open positions, shortlisted candidates, interviews, offers and accepted offers. A warning appears if shortlisted candidates have waited more than 14 days.

Organization coordinators can manage settings and openings, but only owners and recruiters can view candidates.

# 15 Recruiters and hiring partners

Companies that want to take part should see `/hire`, then contact the platform through `/contact` with the topic **Hiring**. The organizer then adds you as a recruiter. You need an OmniHack account first.

## Your Hiring tab

Open **Organizer console**, choose the competition and open **Hiring**. A recruiter sees only their own company's data.

| VIEW | WHAT YOU DO THERE |
|---|---|
| **Talent pool** | Search by name, skill or institution, and filter by opportunity type, result band, award winners or pipeline status. Only participants who opted in are listed. Select **Shortlist** for an opening or as general interest. |
| **Candidate profile** | Read the profile, download the CV, check certificates and read the shared project. The email address appears after you shortlist the candidate. Every view is logged. |
| **Pipeline** | Send an interview invitation (time and format or link), make an offer (type and details), or close an application as not selected with an optional message. Keep private notes, which the candidate never sees. |
| **Openings** | Post or edit roles: title, type, work mode, locations, skills, description, stipend or compensation, duration, positions and closing date. An opening that has candidates is closed rather than deleted. |

Candidates are notified by email at every step and answer from their own dashboard. You are notified when they accept, decline or withdraw. Send the formal offer letter yourself, outside OmniHack.

**RULES FOR RECRUITERS**

Use candidate data only for recruitment for the stated roles. Recruiters never see judges' scores or comments, participants who did not opt in, or other companies' pipelines. Reply to shortlisted candidates within 14 days.

# 16 Other competition roles

| ROLE | ACCESS |
| --- | --- |
| **Event operations coordinator** | Check-in, schedule, slots, announcements, support and volunteers |
| **Sponsor representative** | A read-only sponsor report with aggregate figures (registrations, institutions, teams, projects, attendance) and sponsor award winners once published. No personal data. |
| **Read-only auditor** | Can view the competition and its audit log, and cannot change anything |
| **Volunteer** | Can see their duty and help at the check-in desk where assigned |

# 17 Platform administrators

**Administration** appears in the sidebar for platform admins. If two-factor authentication is required, set it up first under Profile & security.

- **Approvals:** review competitions with the status *Awaiting approval*. Approve them to publish, or return them to draft with a reason.
- **Users:** search accounts and suspend or reactivate them. Super admins can also change platform roles.
- **Organizations:** verify trusted organizations so their competitions publish without review.
- **Competitions:** feature competitions on the homepage.
- **Inquiries:** read contact-form messages by topic, including hiring enquiries from companies.
- **Audit log:** see platform-wide sensitive actions.
- **System:** check integration status (email, storage, malware scanning), the email outbox and background jobs.

# 18 How scoring works

The same rules are published to everyone at `/resources#scoring`.

- **Rubric:** each criterion has a weight, and the weights total 100%. Each also has a score range.
- **One judge's total** runs from 0 to 100. For each criterion, the score is scaled to its range and multiplied by the criterion's weight, and the results are added up. For example, 8 out of a 0–10 range on a 25% criterion adds 20 points.
- **Project score:** the average of the finalized evaluations. Revoked evaluations and evaluations with a declared conflict are left out.
- **Ranking:** ties are broken in this order: higher score, then the tie-break criteria in order, then the earlier final submission, then a fixed fallback. Every scored project gets a unique rank.
- **Advancement:** top N, top percent (rounded up), minimum score, or a manual decision by the organizer.
- **Corrections** need a reason, and the before and after values are kept in the audit log.

For example, the default hackathon technical rubric is: technical execution 30%, impact & usefulness 25%, innovation 20%, design & usability 15%, documentation 10%.

# 19 Troubleshooting

**I never received the verification email**

Check spam, then use **Resend** on the dashboard banner. Check that your email address on Profile & security has no typo. On a local installation, emails are printed to the server terminal instead of being sent (see §02).

**"Verify your email address before creating an organization"**

Creating an organization needs a verified email address. Verify it, then reload the console page.

**The Register button is missing or disabled**

Registration may not be open yet, may be closed, or the competition may be full. You may also not meet the eligibility rules. The competition page shows the reason.

**I can't submit**

Check that the stage is open, that your team size is within the limits, that your registration is approved, and, for later stages, that your project advanced. Required fields are highlighted.

**A teammate can't join my team**

They need an approved registration for the competition, must not already be in another team, and the team must have a free seat.

**My file upload was rejected**

Use an allowed file type within the size limit shown under the field. A file flagged by the malware scan is blocked for everyone's safety.

**I can't join the talent pool**

The competition must have hiring switched on, your registration must be approved, and you must confirm you are 18 or older and give consent. CVs must be PDF files of 5 MB or less.

**Times look wrong**

Competition times are shown in the competition's own time zone, which is printed next to dates. Convert them to your local time if you are elsewhere.

**I'm locked out after too many attempts**

Sign-in and verification are rate-limited. Wait a few minutes and try again, or reset your password.

# 20 Demo accounts and current limits

## Demo accounts (local and test installations only)

A development installation seeded with `npm run db:seed` includes demo accounts. They all use the password `OmniHack!Demo2026`, unless the operator set `SEED_ADMIN_PASSWORD`. All demo data is labelled "(Demo)".

| EMAIL | ROLE TO TRY |
|---|---|
| `admin@omnihack.example` | Platform super admin |
| `organizer@omnihack.example` | Organization owner and competition organizer |
| `coordinator@omnihack.example` | Organization coordinator |
| `judge1@omnihack.example` – `judge3@…` | Judges |
| `mentor@omnihack.example` | Mentor |
| `recruiter@omnihack.example` | Recruiter for "Example Tech (Demo)" |
| `alice@…`, `bob@…`, `carol@…`, `dan@…`, `erin@…`, `frank@…`, `grace@…`, `henry@…` | Participants (all `@omnihack.example`) |

**NEVER ON A LIVE SITE**

The seed refuses to run in production. Do not create these accounts on a public installation.

## Not available yet

- **Paid registration and payments.** These stay disabled until a payment provider is chosen. Paid competitions cannot be published, and per-hire fees for recruitment are not available.
- **AI features.** These are shown as unavailable.
- **SMS and WhatsApp notifications.** Only in-app notifications and email are available.
- **Excel exports.** Exports are CSV files, which open in Excel.

- **Connections to companies' hiring systems and calendar invites.**

---

OmniHack user manual · Questions not covered here? Use `/contact` on the website, or the **Need help?** card in your competition workspace.